Like all other countries, India has always had an active neighbourhood policy. By the end of the 1990s and the beginning of the new century, this policy registered a positive shift. Landmarked by the Gujral Doctrine of 1997, its core was followed by the succeeding regimes headed by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Atal Bihari Vajpayee (1998–2004) and the United Progressive Alliance (2004–2014), headed by Dr Manmohan Singh of the Indian National Congress.

The Modi government's "neighbourhood first" initiative came in the form of an invitation to all the heads of governments of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) countries to witness the swearing-in ceremony of Prime Minister Modi in New Delhi on 26 May 2014. The invitations gave a vague idea of what the new government considered its "neighbourhood" that deserved policy priority. Besides SAARC members, Mauritius was invited but not Myanmar (immediate neighbour), Thailand and Indonesia (maritime neighbours), or even China (the new neighbour). Interestingly, the Prime Minister of the Tibetan government-in-exile operating from India was present at the swearing-in event, although not as a guest of the Prime Minister but perhaps on the invitation of the ruling BJP. The Ambassador of the People's Republic of China took exception to this and registered his protest.[1] But the issue was not politicised, as Chinese Premier Li Keqiang sent a message to Modi within 24 hours of his assuming office to underline the huge potential of cooperation existing between the two countries.

The "neighbourhood first" policy was, however, launched in an ad hoc manner, more as a phrase expressing a sentiment than a well-defined policy like the Gujral Doctrine. Modi tried to assure support and cooperation to all the visiting leaders from the neighbouring countries in his one-on-one meetings. Then–Foreign Secretary Sujatha Singh